

THE ATHLETE CIRCLE

A FREE GUIDE

The 5 Decisions That Make or Break Every Student Athlete's Career

For student athletes and the parents who guide them

THE ATHLETE CIRCLE

athletecircle.ai

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OUR PROMISE TO YOUR FAMILY

*Talent opens doors.
The right Circle determines what happens next.*

Clarity — We replace confusion with structured frameworks and clear next steps.

Protection — We help you see irreversible decisions before they happen — not after.

Alignment — We work for the athlete and the family. Never for the deal.

That is the promise behind every page that follows.

Why This Guide Exists

There has never been a more lucrative — or more complicated — moment to be a young athlete.

NIL didn't just change how athletes earn. It changed who's calling, what they're offering, and how early the stakes get real. By the time a junior in high school posts a recruiting reel, agents, brand managers, financial advisors, and self-appointed "mentors" are already in the DMs. By the time a freshman steps onto a college campus, contracts are crossing the table.

Almost no family is handed a structure for sorting signal from noise. That is not a failure on your part. Nobody built one. Schools handle eligibility. Agents handle deals. Nobody is responsible for the family sitting at the kitchen table trying to decide what to do next.

This guide is that structure.

Five decisions. A framework for each. Written for the athlete and the parent to work through together — because these are family decisions, and several of them require an adult to sign.

You do not need to get all five right at once. You need to know what they are, in what order they tend to arrive, and who in your family owns which one. That is what the next few pages give you.

| *Talent opens the door. The right decisions determine what walks through.*

This is a free guide, and it is built to be useful on its own. If you want the full system — scorecards, contract red-flag checklists, outreach templates, tax structure guidance, and the complete case study — the *Build Your Athlete Circle* playbook goes deeper at athletecircle.ai.

How to Use This Guide

Read it together. About twenty-five minutes.

This guide is written for two readers at once — the athlete and the parent or guardian. Both of you should read it. If you are reading alone right now, that is fine. Just do not act alone.

The path

1. **Find your stage.** *Where You Are Right Now* is the next page. It tells you which of the five decisions is live for you today.
2. **Read all five decisions, in order.** Including the ones that are not live yet. Knowing what is coming is most of the advantage.
3. **Run The Family Conversation.** Thirty minutes at a kitchen table. This is the step that turns reading into a plan.
4. **Take the first seven days.** Small, sequenced, and checkable. Under three hours across a week.

The five decisions

1. **Who Gets Close?** — the Circle of five advisory roles
2. **Who Represents You?** — how to evaluate an agent
3. **Which Deals to Take** — the five-question NIL filter
4. **What You Sign** — the contract red-flag checklist
5. **Who You're Becoming** — the operating system behind all of it

What you will have when you finish

- A clear picture of who is standing closest to your decisions, and where the gaps are
- Four questions to ask any agent before you sign anything
- A five-question filter to run on every NIL offer that comes in
- Five contract clauses you will recognize on sight
- One sentence you can say to anyone applying pressure

A note on the two of you

Each decision ends with a short **Who owns this** box — one line for the parent, one for the athlete. Read those out loud. Most family friction around NIL is not disagreement about the right answer. It is confusion about who is supposed to decide.

If the athlete is under 18: every decision in this guide requires a parent or guardian, and several of them legally cannot be made without one. If you found this on your own, send it to your parent and start at Decision 1 together. The Athlete Circle does not collect information from anyone under 18.

Where You Are Right Now

The five decisions do not all arrive at once. They arrive in a sequence, and the sequence depends on where you are standing. Find your row, start there, then read the rest.

YOUR STAGE	WHAT'S ALREADY TRUE	START WITH
High school, 9th–10th grade	No offers yet — but your content is already public, already permanent, and already being read by recruiters.	Decision 5, then Decision 1
High school, junior or senior	Recruiting contact is live. The first handlers, trainers-turned-advisors, and unofficial “mentors” are showing up.	Decision 1, then Decision 2
College, no NIL income yet	School compliance rules apply to you now. Your first offer will arrive with a deadline attached to it.	Decision 1, then Decision 3
College, earning NIL income	Tax exposure and contract terms are already live. Quarterly estimated payments may already be owed.	Decision 4, then Decision 3
Any stage, already signed something	The deal is signed. Your leverage now lives in what you sign next — and in knowing what this one locked out.	Decision 4, then Decision 1

Wherever you start, read all five. The decision that costs families the most is almost always the one they did not know was coming.

Who Gets Close?

The Circle Framework

The most reliable predictor of how a young athlete’s career and finances unfold is not talent. It is the quality of the people standing closest to the decisions.

That is good news. Talent you cannot control. This you can — starting today, at any stage, at any level.

We call it the Circle: five defined advisory roles, each with a clear function and a hard boundary. No role doubles up. No role gets added under pressure.

ROLE	PRIMARY FUNCTION	COMMON MISTAKE
Lawyer	Contract review, structural protection, compliance	Asked to give business or career advice outside legal scope
Agent	Sourcing opportunities, negotiation, market positioning	Asked to also handle money or legal matters
Financial Advisor	Budgeting, tax structure, investment, long-term wealth	Selling investment products dressed up as advice
Trainer	Performance, conditioning, recovery	Becomes an unofficial manager or agent
Mentor	Perspective, character, honest counsel	Confused with a paid guru or a life coach

The pattern that costs families the most is one person playing two roles. The agent who “also handles the money.” The family friend who “also handles the legal side.” It feels efficient, and it usually comes from a good place. It also gives one person a reason to bend a decision away from your long-term outcome.

The move: separate the roles before there is money on the table. It is an easy conversation at zero dollars and a very hard one at two hundred thousand.

The Quick Audit — ten minutes, together

Take the five roles above. For each one, ask three questions:

1. **Is this role filled?** If not, that is a gap — and gaps are the easiest thing on this list to fix.
2. **Is this person also filling another role?** If yes, that is a conflict. Name it out loud before it costs you anything.
3. **Are their incentives aligned with yours?** If you are not sure, that is simply the first conversation to have. Ask directly. Good people answer directly.

WHO OWNS THIS

Parent or guardian — You own the Circle. Vetting, references, engagement letters, and the annual review are adult work — and most of it legally has to be. Start with the lawyer. Every other role gets easier once that one is filled.

Athlete — You own the honesty. Tell your parent who is actually in your DMs, who is offering what, and who has been coming around lately. Nobody can protect you from people your family does not know exist.

GO DEEPER

The full **Build Your Athlete Circle** playbook includes the complete Circle Audit Worksheet, a sequencing guide for when to add each role by career stage, and the five most common Circle failure patterns with the fix for each.

Who Represents You?

The Agent Evaluation Framework

Your agent is your market arm. Their job is to find opportunities, negotiate terms, and position you to win.

Most athletes choose an agent the way they choose a restaurant — whoever has the best pitch and the nicest office. That is understandable. Nobody teaches a nineteen-year-old how to interview the person about to negotiate their financial future.

So here is how.

Three things to understand before the first meeting

Commission comes out of your earnings. A 15% deal on a \$20,000 NIL contract means \$3,000 goes to the agent and \$17,000 — gross, before taxes — comes to you. Have that math clear in your head before anyone starts talking about representation.

Marketing commission is where agents make their real money. An agent who lands a \$200,000 endorsement at 15% earns more from that single deal than from most playing contracts. Knowing this is not cynical. It simply tells you where to read carefully.

An agent's real value is not the deal they bring you. It is the deals they keep you from signing. The wrong deal at the wrong time can lock out an opportunity worth ten times more.

The four questions that matter most

Before you sign with anyone, sit across the table and ask:

- 1. What is your full commission structure — across NIL, endorsement, and playing contracts?** Strong agents answer with specifics, not ranges. Get it in writing.
- 2. Walk me through the last three deals you closed for athletes at roughly my level. What did you negotiate up from the brand's first offer?** This separates deal-closers from order-takers.
- 3. What happens if I want to leave in six months?** A good agent has a clean answer. Hesitation here tells you the contract is built to hold you rather than earn you.
- 4. Tell me about a deal you turned down for an athlete because it was not right.** Agents who never say no are not protecting you. They are chasing volume.

How to run the meeting. Both of you in the room. The parent asks questions 1 and 3 — money and exit are adult questions, and they land differently coming from a parent. The athlete asks 2 and 4 — track record and judgment. Take notes. Then leave without signing anything.

A good agent expects that. **Nobody who deserves your business needs an answer today.**

WHO OWNS THIS

Parent or guardian — You run the commercial half of the meeting and you own the sentence “we will get back to you.” No agreement gets signed without independent legal review — your lawyer, not theirs.

Athlete — You own the fit. You will talk to this person more than you talk to most of your coaches. If the relationship feels off in the first meeting, it does not improve after the signature.

GO DEEPER

The full playbook includes all 8 diagnostic questions, a complete red-flag checklist for agent contracts (tail clauses, IP grants, tied-services clauses), negotiation templates for commission, term length, and carve-outs, and a step-by-step guide for when and how to change agents.

Which Deals to Take

The NIL Deal Filter

Every NIL offer runs through a filter before you respond. Not after. Not halfway through the negotiation. Before.

Five questions, in order. You stop at the first one that fails. The order is the protection — it is what keeps you from talking yourself into a deal you already failed on question one.

The five-question filter

1 — Does this brand align with my values and long-term identity? Would you be comfortable with this partnership being the lead line of your profile in five years? In ten? If the answer is anything other than a clear yes, you are done. Do not proceed to question 2.

2 — What am I actually committing to? Read the deliverables out loud. Then read the exclusivity terms out loud. The volume of work hiding behind “one Instagram post” is the single most common reason athletes end up feeling used by an NIL deal. The post is rarely just a post.

3 — Is the price right? There is a working market rate based on your audience, engagement, sport, and visibility. The table below is your starting point. A brand offering a fraction of the going rate is counting on you not knowing it.

4 — What does this deal lock me out of? Every deal you sign closes other doors. This is the most under-asked question in NIL. A \$5,000 energy drink deal with category exclusivity can block a \$200,000 sports drink opportunity three months later.

5 — Am I structurally ready? Compliance notified? Entity set up? Tax reserve funded? Lawyer reviewed? Even a good deal can hurt you if the infrastructure is not there yet.

Most athletes lose more value to the wrong deals they signed than to the right deals they walked away from.

Market rate reference

AUDIENCE TIER	SINGLE POST	4-WEEK PACKAGE	ANNUAL AMBASSADOR
Under 10K	\$200 – \$1K	\$1K – \$5K	\$5K – \$15K
10K – 50K	\$1K – \$5K	\$5K – \$20K	\$15K – \$50K
50K – 250K	\$5K – \$15K	\$20K – \$75K	\$50K – \$200K
250K+	\$15K+	\$75K+	\$200K+

Mid-market estimates, current as of Q3 2026 (July 2026). Sport, position visibility, engagement rate, and brand budget all shift the range. NIL pricing moves quickly — check the current quarterly update before relying on these figures in a negotiation.

The one sentence that buys you time: “Thanks — send it over in writing and I will come back to you within 48 hours.” Say it every time, to everyone, including people you like. A deal that cannot survive 48 hours was never a deal.

WHO OWNS THIS

Parent or guardian — You own questions 3, 4, and 5 — market rate, category lockouts, and whether the structure is actually in place. You also own the 48-hour clock, because you are the one in the room who is not excited.

Athlete — You own questions 1 and 2 — values and deliverables. Nobody else can tell you what you want to be known for, and nobody else has to do the work written into that contract.

GO DEEPER

The full playbook includes the complete NIL Deal Evaluation Worksheet, a real-world case study walking all five filters across an actual offer, tax structure guidance (LLC vs. sole proprietorship, quarterly estimated payments, multi-state filing), and deal-type breakdowns covering flat fee, affiliate, equity, and ambassadorship structures.

What You Sign

The Contract Red-Flag Checklist

You do not need a law degree to know when to slow down. You need to recognize five patterns. Once you have seen them, you will see them everywhere — and “I need my lawyer to look at clause 4” is a complete, professional sentence that nobody reasonable objects to.

RED FLAG	WHAT IT MEANS	WATCH FOR	THE FIX
Perpetual Rights	The brand can use your name, image, and content forever — long after the deal ends.	“in perpetuity,” “indefinite,” “forever”	Limit to a 12–24 month license with optional renewal.
Unlimited Exclusivity	You cannot sign with other brands in a broadly defined category.	“exclusive worldwide,” “any related category”	Define narrowly. List specific competitors. Put a time limit on it.
Morality Clauses	The brand can terminate — and claw back payments — at its sole discretion.	“objectionable conduct,” “sole discretion”	Require objective standards: actual conviction, documented breach.
Vague Deliverables	The work is open to interpretation, and the brand expects more than you planned.	“reasonable amount,” “as needed,” “mutually agreed”	Itemize everything: number of posts, platforms, dates, approval flow.
No Exit Clause	A multi-year term with no way out, even if the relationship stops working.	Silence on termination rights	Cap the term at 1 year. Add a 30-day no-cause termination right.

The four things you never agree to verbally

Brands and agents will sometimes ask for a commitment before paperwork. Most of that is harmless. These four are not — even said casually on a phone call, they can be argued as binding in a dispute:

1. "I'll wear it on game day."
2. "I'll post X times."
3. "That sounds good — let's do it."
4. "I won't sign with anyone else in the meantime."

Your default response to any verbal pressure: "My team handles all commercial conversations. Can you send the proposed terms in writing? I'll get on a call with my agent and lawyer to walk through it." That is the whole script. Use it every time, with everyone, no exceptions.

If the athlete is under 18, the script is even shorter: "I'm not 18. My parents handle all of this. Please send it to them in writing."

WHO OWNS THIS

Parent or guardian — You own the signature and the legal review. Nothing reaches a lawyer late. Build that relationship before the first contract arrives, not during it.

Athlete — You own what comes out of your mouth. Every verbal commitment gets made by you, in a moment, usually alone. That is why the script above is worth memorizing until it is boring.

GO DEEPER

The full playbook covers all 12 red-flag clauses — including indemnification, auto-renewal, assignability, and liquidated damages — plus a 7-gate decision tree for whether to sign today, anonymized cautionary tales from real NIL situations, and specific negotiation language for each clause.

Who You're Becoming

The Athlete Operating System

The first four decisions are reactive. They fire when something happens to you. This one is proactive.

The athletes who compound their advantages are not the ones who handle each decision brilliantly in the moment. They are the ones operating from a system that already made most of the small decisions, before the moment arrived and asked them to choose.

An athlete with a system makes a thousand small decisions in advance. An athlete without one makes them all under pressure.

The five pillars

Eligibility. Know your school's NIL policy. Save your compliance officer's contact. Disclose proactively. Never sign anything without legal review.

Circle. Five roles. Quarterly review. No role doubles up. Mentor connection monthly. Annual legal review of every active agreement.

Brand. Write your brand promise in three sentences. Read it before every content decision. Post intentionally, not reactively. Update your highlight reel quarterly.

Finance. 30% of every NIL dollar goes to a tax reserve. 10% goes to long-term investing. Quarterly CPA check-in. No major purchase without 72 hours and a Circle conversation.

Legacy. Once a quarter, write one page on what you want to be known for in ten years. Run every major decision through that page. Family conversations about money happen openly.

The quarterly review — sixty minutes that change everything

Once a quarter, sit down — with a parent, or with your closest advisor — and answer four questions:

1. **What worked last quarter?** Deals signed, deals declined, relationships that produced, content that moved.
2. **Where is the weakest pillar?** Score each of the five from 1 to 5. The lowest score is the work.
3. **What are the one to three most important things in the next 90 days?** Pipeline deals, conversations to have, conversations to end.
4. **Is what I am doing aligned with who I am becoming?** Read your legacy page. If the answer is no, change something deliberately rather than drifting.

WHO OWNS THIS

Parent or guardian — You own the calendar. Put the quarterly review on it and protect the hour. Systems almost never die from being wrong — they die from never being scheduled.

Athlete — You own the legacy page. One page, once a quarter, in your own words. Nobody can write that one for you, and it is the page every other decision gets measured against.

GO DEEPER

The full playbook includes the complete Athlete Operating System with standing orders for each pillar, the Athlete-As-A-Business metrics dashboard (10 numbers to track), an optionality discipline framework, the Legacy Statement worksheet, a Sandler-based brand outreach playbook with templates, and a 30-day action plan to put all of it into motion.

The Family Conversation

Thirty minutes. One table. No phones.

Everything in this guide stays theory until your family has this conversation once. Have it before there is an offer on the table rather than after — money makes every one of these questions harder to answer honestly.

Five questions, in this order

1. **What are we actually trying to build?** Not “go pro.” What does a good outcome look like in ten years if the sport ends tomorrow? Both of you answer. Write both answers down. They are usually closer than either of you expects.
2. **Who is already close to us, and why?** Name everyone who has offered help in the last year. For each one, ask what they get out of this. That is not a cynical question — it is an honest one. Aligned incentives are fine. Unexamined ones are the problem.
3. **What are we not willing to do for money?** Categories, brands, behaviors. Decide it now, in the quiet, while the decision costs nothing.
4. **Who decides what?** Go back through the five *Who owns this* boxes in this guide. Read them out loud. Agree on them. This single step prevents most of the conflict that shows up later.
5. **What are we most exposed on right now?** Everyone names one thing. Then pick the single one you will fix first, and say when.

When you disagree

You will. The usual split: the athlete sees the opportunity, the parent sees the risk. Both of you are seeing correctly — you are just looking at different time horizons.

The rule that resolves most of it: **the athlete decides what they want to be known for. The parent decides what gets signed.** Neither one vetoes the other’s lane.

Then set the next one

Ninety days out. Same five questions. Put it on the calendar before anyone leaves the table — a conversation that happens once is a nice evening, and a conversation that happens quarterly is a system.

You're Not Behind

Most families find this guide after something has already happened. A deal already signed. An agent already hired. A verbal commitment already made. Money already spent that should have gone to taxes.

That is the normal starting point, not the exception. Almost nobody arrives here early.

Here is what is true: **almost nothing is unfixable, and the things that are get smaller the sooner you look at them.**

- **Signed a deal you regret?** Almost every deal has a term. Have a lawyer read it, find out what it actually locks you out of, and put the end date on a calendar. The next deal is where you apply what this one taught you.
- **Wrong agent?** Nearly every agreement has an exit. Find it, read the notice period, and understand the tail clause before you say anything to anyone. Then run Decision 2 properly the next time.
- **Have not set aside taxes?** Start today at 30% of every new dollar, and talk to a CPA this month about what is owed on the old ones. This is the most fixable item on the list and the one families avoid the longest.
- **Made a verbal commitment you regret?** Get the current state in writing, in neutral language, as soon as you can. Ambiguity is what hurts you later. A written record — even an imperfect one — almost always helps.
- **Nobody in the Circle at all?** Fill one role. The lawyer. That is the entire first step, and it is enough for this week.

The athletes who end up in strong positions are rarely the ones who started perfectly. They are the ones who looked at the situation honestly and made the next decision better than the last one.

The Connor Barry Story

Every framework in this guide was built alongside a real athlete running the system in real time. His name is Connor Barry. His story is worth knowing — not because it is extraordinary, but because it is repeatable.

The path

Connor was named Northern Virginia Football Hall of Fame Player of the Year after captaining James Madison High School in Vienna, Virginia to a 13–2 season and a state runner-up finish, the most accomplished season in school history. He finished 22–3 as a starter. He received no FBS scholarship offers. He walked on at Appalachian State, sat behind three quarterbacks, and never appeared in a game.

Most stories end there. Connor's did not.

He transferred to Christopher Newport University, a Division III program in Newport News, Virginia, and rebuilt from the ground up. As a sophomore he took over the starting job midseason. As a junior in 2025 he led CNU to the first undefeated regular season in school history at 10–0 and set school records for passing efficiency and touchdown passes.

RECOGNITION

- **Northern Virginia Football Hall of Fame Player of the Year** (2021)
- **Touchdown Club of Richmond Quarterback of the Year in Virginia** (2024)
- **NJAC Offensive Player of the Year** (2025)
- **AFCA Second-Team All-American** (2025)
- **Gagliardi Trophy semifinalist** — the first in CNU football history (2025)

In December 2025, Penn State hired Matt Campbell as head coach. Quarterbacks coach Jake Waters followed him from Iowa State and made contact. Connor visited campus in mid-January, committed on January 22, 2026, and signed in early February. By spring practice he was taking the bulk of the first- and second-team reps, and Campbell called him “probably the surprise” of camp.

A Division III quarterback, in a Big Ten quarterback room, in his first spring.

The system behind the story

Connor's Circle was built before the spotlight arrived. His agent handles all commercial conversations — no exceptions. His family runs quarterly reviews. His brand is anchored in faith and family, and every NIL opportunity is filtered through that identity before price is ever discussed. He has turned down deals that paid well and did not align. He has avoided verbal commitments. He has run the same unglamorous system, week after week, while building something designed to last decades instead of months.

Connor was not a five-star recruit. He is not a Heisman frontrunner. He is a Big Ten quarterback with a clear identity, a structured Circle, and a system — and every part of that is available to any athlete, at any level, starting today.

Performance opens the door. The system is what walks through it.

Career detail current as of April 2026. Connor Barry's story and likeness are used with family consent.

Your First Seven Days

If you have read this far, you already understand the business side of this better than most college juniors signing deals right now. That is real, and it counts.

But knowing and doing are different sports, and the gap between them is almost always just a missing first step. So here is a week.

DAY	DO THIS	WHO	TIME
1	Run the Circle Audit. Five roles, three questions each. Write down which role is empty and which person is wearing two hats.	Together	15 min
2	Open a separate account for taxes. Move 30% of every NIL dollar received to date into it.	Parent	20 min
3	Write the brand promise. Three sentences: who you are, what you stand for, what kind of partner belongs next to your name.	Athlete	20 min
4	Find one lawyer. Ask two families you trust for a referral, or ask your compliance office for a list. You are not hiring today — you are making the first call.	Parent	30 min
5	Save your compliance officer's contact in both of your phones. Read your school's NIL disclosure policy together.	Together	20 min
6	Memorize the script: "My team handles all commercial conversations. Send the proposed terms in writing." Say it out loud until it is boring.	Athlete	5 min
7	Run The Family Conversation. Set the next one 90 days out before anyone leaves the table.	Together	30 min

Under three hours across a week. At the end of it you have a tax account, a first legal contact, a written identity, a compliance line, a script, and a plan — which is more infrastructure than most athletes have in place when their first real offer arrives.

READY FOR THE FULL SYSTEM?

Build Your Athlete Circle

A Decision Playbook for the Modern Athlete

5 complete modules · Worksheets & scorecards · Contract red-flag checklists

Outreach templates · The full Connor Barry case study · 30-day action plan

Free 15-minute strategy call · 12 months of quarterly updates

\$97

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Share this guide freely. The more athletes and parents who understand these decisions early, the fewer learn them the hard way.

Disclaimer

This guide is educational. It is not legal advice, financial advice, or representation. The frameworks here help you ask better questions and identify risk earlier — they do not replace a licensed attorney, a registered financial advisor, or a properly vetted agent. Before signing any agreement, get qualified professional review.

The Athlete Circle is written for student athletes and for the parents and guardians who guide them. Athletes under 18 should read this material with a parent or guardian, and every decision in it that requires a signature is a parent or guardian decision. We do not knowingly collect personal information from anyone under 18. Anyone under 18 who reaches athletecircle.ai is directed to share the site with a parent or guardian. Email signups and purchases are for adults only.

Market rates, regulatory references, and enforcement patterns described in this guide reflect conditions as of July 2026 and are subject to change. Career detail in the Connor Barry section is current as of April 2026.